



ManTech®
Securing the Future

Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan

Response to Request for Information (RFI)

March 14, 2025

Submitted via Email To

Office of Science and Technology Policy
Networking and Information Technology
Research and Development, National
Science Foundation
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March 14, 2025

NCO
2415 Eisenhower Avenue
Alexandria, VA 22314

Subject: Request for Information (RFI) Response: Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan

Mr. Faisal D'Souza,

On behalf of ManTech International Corporation (ManTech), we welcome the opportunity to respond to the Office of Science and Technology Policy's (OSTP) request for information (RFI) regarding the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan. At ManTech, we recognize the critical importance of sustaining and enhancing American AI dominance and appreciate this Administration's focus on reducing and removing requirements that hamper private sector innovation in AI.

At ManTech, we share OSTP's belief that a successful national AI Action Plan must address the challenges of today while preparing for the opportunities of tomorrow. This response outlines ManTech's perspectives on key areas, including strategic investments, a balanced regulatory framework, and modernized procurement approaches. Our recommendations are grounded in a commitment to fostering American leadership in AI, while ensuring that the benefits of this technology are shared broadly across society.

We appreciate the opportunity to contribute to this important initiative and welcome the prospect of further engagement. This document is approved for public dissemination. The document contains no business-proprietary or confidential information. Document contents may be reused by the government in developing the AI Action Plan and associated documents without attribution.

Respectfully,

Brandy Durham
Vice President, Data and AI Practice
ManTech International Corporation



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1.0 INTRODUCTION

The rapid advancement of artificial intelligence (AI) creates both unprecedented opportunities and complex challenges for the United States. An AI Action Plan is necessary to sustain and enhance American global leadership in this transformative technology. This document responds to the Request for Information (RFI) by outlining key recommendations for an AI Action Plan across strategic investments, regulatory frameworks and procurement strategies.

ManTech's perspective is rooted in the understanding that a successful AI Action Plan must be multifaceted and address core technological development, workforce preparation and market dynamics. We recognize the urgent need to move beyond a fragmented landscape of state-level regulations to an established, clear, national vision that empowers innovation, and both furthers and protects national interests.

Our response focuses on three key areas in which the Federal Government can bring about and foster the greatest changes while not overburdening innovation:

- 1) Strategic Investments:** We propose a three-pronged strategic investment approach that (1) integrates AI into existing systems to meet the needs of today; (2) prioritizes foundational research to seed the technology of tomorrow; and (3) cultivates a future AI-ready workforce. This approach incorporates targeted funding for AI research, development of synthetic data to ensure continued scalability of AI models and mitigate privacy concerns, and educational programs that emphasize critical thinking and problem-solving. We recommend tax policies that incentivize collaboration and infrastructure development, recognizing that a robust AI ecosystem requires a strong foundation. Tax policies promoting AI are a strategic investment that will result in long-term economic growth and generate future tax revenue.
- 2) Regulatory Framework - Fostering Innovation Through Balanced Government:** We believe that a minimum amount of federal guidance is necessary to prevent a patchwork of state laws that can create conflicting regulations, burdensome bureaucracy, and stifle innovation. Clear federal principles should be established while allowing domain-specific regulations that can adapt to rapid technological change. This guidance should minimize confusion and maximize consistency.
- 3) Procurement Approaches:** We advocate for using modernized procurement approaches that reduce barriers to entry for non-traditional companies, streamline acquisition, and leverage novel procurement methods to achieve flexible, outcome-driven contract vehicles.

2.0 STRATEGIC INVESTMENTS

As global competition for AI leadership intensifies, the Federal Government must continue to take a leadership role in fostering basic and applied research in AI, advancing private-sector development, and encouraging novel and innovative approaches to AI deployment that address the most challenging use-cases.

AI development requires close collaboration across government, industry and academia. While industry will lead in innovation, the government plays a pivotal role in encouraging private investment and partnerships, establishing a national vision, and especially in supporting emerging AI technologies through funding with pilot programs. The Federal Government can also uniquely positioned to play a constructive role in supporting the fundamental resources that underpin AI (e.g. energy distribution, data centers, workforce development), and clearing away barriers to growth and innovation, such as environmental regulations that inhibit investments.

AI requires significant infrastructure investments, from the advanced computing chips required to develop the next generation of advanced AI capabilities, to the facilities needed to house the large volumes of hardware. There is insufficient power required to cool and run all the resources required for AI on existing infrastructure. To accelerate next-generation AI development, the government should create additional incentives to promote the creation of new data centers, enhance accessible high quality computing capabilities, and improve our electrical infrastructure to better handle the massive power consumption needed to develop advanced AI capabilities. Incentives such as tax credits will encourage private-sector strategic planning and investment in these areas.

Tax Policy: In addition to infrastructure, the Federal Government can leverage tax policy to shape and support AI development and innovation, allowing private companies to do what they do best: *innovate*.

- **Extend Tax Cuts.** The Federal Government should extend parts of the Tax Cuts and Jobs Act, which are set to expire at the end of 2025. Extending these credits would provide a more favorable environment for companies that are looking to mitigate risks from research and development (R&D) investments and potentially free up resources for direct investment in AI infrastructure and experimentation.
- **Expand R&D Tax Credits.** Expanding the R&D tax credit (IRC Section 41) to include specific credits for AI research and development would encourage producers and consumers of AI to innovate and adopt new technologies. Allowing private AI companies to deduct research expenses, salaries for data scientists and researchers, investments in AI-related cloud computing, AI algorithms, and model development will encourage innovative companies to take more risks and bring new capabilities to market.
- **Offer Tax Benefits for Modernization.** Offering tax benefits to companies focusing on national security to invest now to replace old servers, storage, processors, and software in favor of advanced AI-ready products, will encourage the private sector to modernize its technology to support AI sustainment and enhancement. This incentive would include a defined sunset period to encourage modernization sooner and limit the overall costs.

Public-Private Partnerships (PPP): ManTech believes that emphasizing and expanding PPPs is key to advancing AI development. As with other new technologies, government

collaboration with the private sector can make a significant difference in accelerating the development of AI in the United States and helping to maintain our leadership position:

- *AI will impact all industries.* The Federal Government could prioritize collaboration in industries that are critical to national competitive advantage (e.g., defense, software, supply chain, energy, healthcare/biomedical, and microelectronics).
- *Cybersecurity case study.* Many companies retain highly talented staff with a strong interest in creating leading-edge AI capabilities. Successful collaboration between government and industry to advance AI for cyber in the protection of the nation's critical infrastructure is a great example of a case study in PPPs.
- *Enhanced knowledge sharing.* Government can better promote, participate, and facilitate technology transfer events such as conferences, seminars and summits. This can help foster collaboration between government and industry. Such events benefit government and industry, demonstrating the “art of the possible” to government representatives while providing industry with invaluable feedback on the current trends and areas of government interest.

AI Data Centers: AI will continue to drive the need for massive amounts of computer processing, electricity and data centers. While there is ample power generation capacity, the power companies cannot keep pace with power distribution infrastructure to service current and planned facilities. This energy gap could delay building new data centers until the power distribution capacity is in place. New research and investments are needed to develop additional modes of onsite power generation to reduce the data centers' reliance on the power grid. The Federal Government can also play a role in providing incentives for data center providers to upgrade their infrastructure to handle the heavy AI workloads, particularly as it relates to cooling, power, and rack density.

Workforce Development: As the United States competes for leadership in AI, it needs a highly skilled workforce that can scale to match the growth of the industry. To continue to develop a skilled AI workforce, the Federal Government could facilitate the following types of activities:

- Partnerships between industry and academia to accelerate the development of AI infrastructure while also training the next generation of AI researchers. The Federal Government can identify grants for universities and tax incentives for corporations that enter into these types of agreements.
- Increasing the integration of AI education into existing Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) curriculum to prepare the next generation for continued AI leadership.
- Developing industry-specific AI training programs that demonstrate how AI can be applied within industries such as defense, healthcare, finance, manufacturing or retail. This could be accomplished in alliance with the AI Research Institutes.
- Leveraging community colleges and training centers to develop standardized certification programs in AI. As with other technical areas, certification programs build confidence in the workforce and allow for more rapid industry growth.

3.0 REGULATORY FRAMEWORK – FOSTERING INNOVATION THROUGH BALANCED GOVERNANCE

The rapid evolution of AI requires a regulatory approach that is both agile and grounded in clear, concise principles. State-level initiatives have demonstrated a proactive engagement with AI policy but have created a fragmented patchwork of regulations that risks hindering innovation, particularly for businesses operating across state lines. We believe that a minimum level of federal guidance is crucial to establish a consistent and predictable regulatory landscape that fosters a national ecosystem conducive to AI advancement.

Federal guidance would not micromanage AI implementation across all sectors. Instead, it could concentrate on establishing focus areas so that domain-specific guidance fosters innovation and allows the technology to evolve at speed. Focus areas to encourage domain-specific guidance or transparency include:

- Developing open standards and protocols for AI systems where those standards and protocols are necessary to ensure interoperability across different platforms and applications. This promotes a more competitive marketplace, reduces vendor lock, and provides a foundation for future AI literacy efforts.
- Establishing clear principles for data access and governance. This could involve elevating existing standards for data anonymization, promoting the use of synthetic data, and establishing standards for data provenance.
- Establishing guidance for technical requirements around explainability and transparency in AI systems. The actual technical requirements and implementation of such guidance could also be tailored by domain.
- Identifying requirements for security and resilience of systems used for national security and critical infrastructure, which could include establishing standards for cybersecurity, vulnerability testing, incident response and supply chain assurance, and would involve identifying and modifying existing guidance in this area.
- Clarifying intellectual property protection for AI systems, which would help to create a more predictable legal environment for AI developers and users.
- Strengthening and streamlining the patent process for AI-related products and processes.

Furthermore, we advocate for a decentralized, domain-specific regulatory approach, that acknowledges the unique challenges presented by different sectors for AI applications. For instance, the regulatory considerations for AI in healthcare differ from those in finance or transportation. Domain-specific regulations, developed in close collaboration with industry experts and stakeholders, can provide necessary granularity to address such nuances effectively.

This decentralized, domain-specific regulatory approach empowers sector-by-sector specific regulatory bodies to develop and adopt guidelines tailored to their unique domain contexts. It would foster a more agile regulatory environment, enabling rapid responses to emerging challenges and technological advancements. Such adaptability is crucial in the rapidly evolving field of AI, where rigid, one-size-fits-all regulations can quickly become obsolete.

Fully decentralized regulation creates the potential of unintentionally creating barriers to reusing technology. To facilitate effective coordination and harmonization across different

domains, we propose empowering an existing body, or establishing a new body composed of both Government and private sector representatives, to focus on information sharing and sharing of best practices across domains. Such a body could play a crucial role in providing guidance to state and local governments, ensuring that their AI-related initiatives align with federal principles.

In essence, ManTech's proposed minimalist regulatory framework strikes the right balance between national consistency and domain-specific flexibility. By establishing clear federal principles and empowering sector-specific regulatory bodies, we can create an environment that fosters innovation and prevents further devolving regulation into a patchwork of state-specific regulations. This approach would not only promote American leadership in AI but also ensures that the benefits of this transformative technology are realized across all sectors of society.

4.0 PROCUREMENT APPROACHES

Government procurement plays a critical role in fostering both general innovation in AI and applications for Government-specific needs. To optimize the speed of value from advancements in AI, it is necessary to modernize and adapt current procurement approaches to foster an environment of innovation and capitalize on emerging commercial technologies. To this end, ManTech recommends a set of approaches that will allow the Federal Government to take advantage of innovative technologies and encourage continued creation of new capabilities that address Federal Government needs.

Reduce the barrier to entry for non-traditional companies: AI advancements are largely driven by the commercial sector, and many of the leading companies have limited experience in Government contracting. Simplifying the procurement regulations to make it easier for companies to enter the Federal market is crucial to enhance competition and ensure government access to state-of-the-art AI-driven technologies.

Procure holistic solutions: Emerging capabilities in AI are broadly transformational. To achieve their full promise requires transforming the environment around them to make use of new capabilities. This includes adapting surrounding systems, data management, processing, and human workflows and tradecraft to effectively leverage these advancements. When the main technical capability is procured separately from other components of a mission or enterprise activity, the elements for transformation may become inconsistent with one another, or the progression of each part may be hampered by requirements for compatibility with legacy versions of the other parts. We recommend that the government procure holistic solutions that include core technologies, adaptation of those technologies, technical integration and professional services to apply the technologies to enterprise needs. Procuring such complete solutions enables the government to reap the full benefits of the AI capabilities.

Utilize new and non-traditional procurement methods for AI: The speed of commercial advances in AI creates significant challenges for traditional government contracting. The time involved in creating a highly precise set of requirements and specifying the desired technology, application, and approach can often coincide with changes in the market that make those specifications outdated by the time the procurement occurs. More broadly, the nature of AI includes a variety of methods that achieve similar functional results. Narrowly specifying the required technology and methods limits the range of offerings and may limit value to the government and stifle relevant innovation. Integrating flexible outcome-based approaches that empower the government and offerors to experiment with different methods, fail fast, and deliver will provide the most effective results. We encourage the government to consider new additional mechanisms that promote experimentation and rapid response, creating a rich ecosystem for acquiring creative, cutting-edge AI solutions.

A key benefit to AI is its ability to augment traditional workflows, improving productivity by automating repeatable time-consuming processes. To improve government efficiency, it is key to ensure the workforce has access to, knows how to use, and feels empowered to adopt cutting-edge AI capabilities. Current acquisition processes can get in the way of broad scale adoption. Many AI capabilities have a high initial cost associated with their procurement; the efficiency of these capabilities can often provide a much greater return on investment by significantly cutting down on the man-hours necessary to perform tasks.

When evaluating a time-cost tradeoff associated with acquisitions, both the value of the time that a proposed capability will save the government, and the value of expediting mission delivery are important to consider.

Prioritize AI in authorization activities: For the government to benefit fully from AI advances, government entities must be able to use advances in the technical environments where they perform the core of their work. This requires authorization for systems at all levels of classification, and often additional authorization is required for specialized enclaves. This critical security assurance and authorization to operate must be achieved while also increasing the speed of access to AI capabilities and without increasing risk. We recommend that an AI Action Plan prioritize AI-enabled solutions in authorization reviews. We further recommend consideration of reciprocity for all security elements reviewed by other entities or lower levels of authorization, to streamline each review to the extent possible and efficiently deliver technology to the most critical missions.

Procure solutions from a variety of providers: Leadership in AI technology development and adoption is constantly evolving. The broad economy will benefit from access to the full panoply of both core technology and applications companies and the competition this brings. Likewise, the government will benefit from a broad range of providers offering technology solutions to the government. Competition will create innovation, drive down prices, ensure the continuous incorporation of the best new capabilities from the commercial sector, and encourage continued investment in the enhancement of capabilities. To build the foundation for a dynamic competitive environment, we urge the government to procure solutions from a variety of AI providers to ensure early-stage robust competition. Selecting a single provider, even if this provider has the current leading capability, will discourage others from entering the government marketplace, and may result in a market where a single dominant provider has few incentives to innovate or constrain costs. Instead, we recommend procurement from a mixture of sources. We also suggest considering potential minimum buys, to attract attention to the government market from commercial leaders focused on enterprise deals and large markets, and to ensure viability of multiple such leaders with differing strengths and areas of technical emphasis.

5.0 CONCLUSION

The United States stands at a pivotal moment in the evolution of AI. To maintain our global leadership and ensure that AI benefits all Americans, a comprehensive and forward-looking AI Action Plan is essential. This response has outlined key recommendations across strategic investment, regulatory frameworks, and procurement approaches, emphasizing the need for a balanced approach that fosters innovation while safeguarding public interests.

By prioritizing strategic investments in research, infrastructure and workforce development, we can lay the foundation for a thriving AI ecosystem. By establishing a clear and adaptable regulatory framework, we can provide certainty and guidance while encouraging rapid AI development. By modernizing procurement approaches, we can ensure that the government has access to the most innovative AI solutions.

We believe that by embracing these recommendations, the United States can harness the transformative potential of AI to drive economic growth, enhance national security and improve the lives of all Americans. We appreciate the opportunity to provide our recommendations to the AI Action Plan and look forward to future participation in additional associated activities.